and arrested Shekhar and a female singer also present in Singapore. Soon after, Zubeen's cousin Sandipan Garg, a policeman who had accompanied him to Singapore, was arrested as well.

On October 11 came the arrest of two of Zubeen's private security officers provided by the government. Nandeswar Bora and Paresh Baishya, both from Assam Police, were booked after the SIT flagged suspicious bank transactions. The probe widened as some members of the Assam Association in Singapore, which hosted the yacht party, came under media glare. All of them, barring one who is a Singapore citizen, gave their statements to the SIT in Guwahati. Every development was scrutinised in millions of social media posts, turning the probe into a public spectacle. People questioned why the SIT hadn't inspected the 'scene of crime'. Eventually, a two-member team was sent. Under mounting pressure, Singapore authorities, while reiterating there was no foul play, opened an inquiry under the Coroners Act, a procedure for unexplained deaths.

POLITICAL THEATRE UNFOLDS

It didn't take long for political parties to seize on the public outrage. Gaurav Gogoi accused Himanta of shielding Shyamkanu and later alleged that he continued to receive privileged treatment despite arrest, sealed home, frozen accounts and being forced to wear the same clothes for a week in jail. He also questioned the SIT's composition, claiming it included only Himanta's loyalists.

Gogoi brought the Congress high command into the fold by persuading Rahul Gandhi to visit Zubeen's funeral site on October 17. Rahul's visit, 28 days after Zubeen's death, signalled how the tragedy could become Assam's central political flashpoint ahead of the 2026 election. On October 19, the opposition staged a show of unity at a public memorial in Guwahati, which was attended by members of Congress, Raijor Dal, Assam Jatiya Parishad and cultural figures.

Raijor Dal's Akhil Gogoi, Sarma's rival from college days, accused the CM's wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sarma, of showing

CAST OF A TRAGEDY IN MANY ACTS

Key players caught in the storm surrounding Zubeen Garg's death



On September 19, Assamese singer and icon Zubeen Garg died while swimming off Singapore's St John's Island. He had been partying on a yacht with about a dozen people, including his manager, a police officer cousin, and several Assamese expatriates. He was in Singapore to attend the Northeast India Festival



His sudden death triggered massive outrage in Assam. Many blamed Northeast Festival organiser Shyamkanu Mahanta (left) and Zubeen's manager Siddhartha Sharma (right) for taking an ailing Zubeen to Singapore and letting him swim, despite medical advice against aquatic activities following two years of seizures

Opposition parties and social media influencers alleged that CM Himanta Biswa Sarma was shielding Shyamkanu because of his family ties



Shyamkanu is the brother of Assam Information Commissioner and former DGP Bhaskar Jyoti Mahanta (left), and Gauhati University Vice Chancellor Nani Gopal Mahanta (right, Sarma's close associate who also hosted RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat twice at his home)



Graphic by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**